The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

The **Trump** administration fast-tracked $8.6bn in arms sales to America's allies in the Middle East, including the UAE, Israel, Kuwait and Qatar. Invoking an emergency authorisation, the State Department bypassed Congress, which typically approves such sales. Countries in the Middle East have faced repeated Iranian missile and drone attacks since war broke out, depleting their existing stocks of missile interceptors.

Donald Trump said he would review **Iran's** latest proposal for a peace deal, but would also consider resuming strikes against military targets in the country if its leaders were to "misbehave". Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, said his government were willing to continue negotiating with America if it avoided "excessive demands, threatening rhetoric, and provocative actions".

Berkshire Hathaway reported first-quarter operating profit of $11.4bn—an 18% year-on-year increase. Several parts of the sprawling conglomerate contributed to the higher earnings, including its retail, manufacturing and insurance divisions. Its cash pile grew from $371bn to $397bn, its highest ever level. The results mark a strong start to Greg Abel's tenure as boss; he took over from Warren Buffett in January.

Somali pirates hijacked an oil tanker off the coast of **Yemen**, according to the BBC. Yemen's coast guard confirmed that the MT Eureka, which was flying under the flag of Togo, was seized in the Gulf of Aden and heading towards Somalia. Ten days ago Somali pirates hijacked a different oil tanker in the area.

Oleksandr Syrsky, the head of **Ukraine's** army, said Russian forces had nearly reached the outskirts of **Kostiantynivka**, one of several fortified towns in the eastern Donetsk region. The "fortress belt" of towns span a defensive line holding Russia back from the 19% of the region still controlled by Ukraine. Mr Syrsky said Ukrainian forces had repulsed "persistent attempts" by Russian troops to infiltrate the city.

Spirit Airlines ceased operations after failing to secure a $500m bailout from the Trump administration. The low-cost carrier said it was working to get stranded employees home and passengers refunds. It filed for its second bankruptcy last year amid growing competition and a blocked merger with JetBlue; soaring energy prices have caused additional strain.

Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, told the BBC that some **protests** may be stopped in the wake of an **antisemitic attack** in London. Some Jewish leaders have called for pro-Palestinian marches to be temporarily halted. On Wednesday a man stabbed two Jewish men in Golders Green, an area with a big Jewish population. Police arrested a suspect at the scene; the victims survived with serious injuries.

Word of the week: *döstädning*, "death-cleaning", the Swedish practice of decluttering before death to spare loved ones from having to do so afterwards. Read more in our obituary of Margareta Magnusson, who brought the concept to the rest of the world.

Photograph: Getty Images

An awkward meeting for OPEC

Seven heavyweight members of the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and some allies will meet on Sunday to set production quotas for June. The cartel is expected to nudge them higher, but its decision will be purely academic. Three of its 11 members (all Gulf producers) cannot export much—the Strait of Hormuz is closed. They have cut output since March, not raised it. The other four have little spare capacity.

The timing is awkward. This week the United Arab Emirates, formerly OPEC's third-largest producer, quit the cartel. It has vowed to boost output once Hormuz reopens, shifting the burden of managing global supply onto those who remain, above all Saudi Arabia. OPEC's self-described mandate is to ensure stable prices, fair returns for producers and a steady supply to consumers. Yet prices have spiked and Gulf export revenues have collapsed. Consumers are starved of fuel. An organisation founded to control the market has never looked less in command.

Photograph: Getty Images

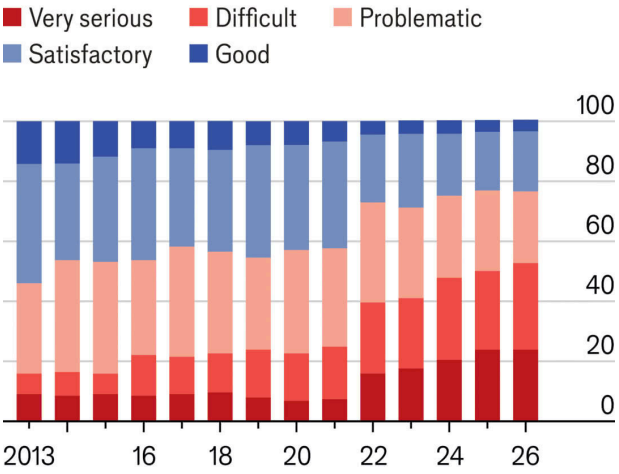
Press freedom falls to a new low

In 1993 the UN designated May 3rd World Press Freedom Day as a reminder of the need to protect editorial independence. That message has increasingly fallen on deaf ears. Press freedom is at its lowest level in 25 years.

The proliferation of armed conflict, growing authoritarianism and the criminalisation of journalism have all contributed to the decline. According to Reporters Without Borders, a non-profit organisation, conditions in over half of the world's countries are now "difficult" or "very serious" for press freedom. America has fallen to its lowest spot ever, ranking 64th out of 180 countries. Less than 1% of the global population (mainly in northern Europe) live in countries where the watchdog deems press freedom to be "good". Zambia will host journalists and politicians on Monday for a UN-backed conference to tackle these challenges. Yet the barriers to independent journalism are unlikely to be lifted soon.

Hard-pressed

World Press Freedom, by category, % of countries



Source: RSF World Press Freedom Index

Photograph: Photographic Archive Museo Nacional del Prado

Spain’s forgotten master

The artist Francisco de Zurbarán was once hailed by Philip IV of Spain as a “king of painters”. Yet centuries on, he remains far less known outside of his country than contemporaries such as Diego Velázquez or Bartolomé Esteban Murillo. That may explain why Britain has never devoted a major exhibition to him—until now.

The National Gallery in London has brought together around 50 of his works in an exhibition that opens this weekend, offering a chance to see what sets him apart. Zurbarán’s paintings are simple but striking: dark backgrounds, strong contrasts of light and shadow, and an intense focus on solitary figures. His most recognisable work, “Agnus Dei”, a bound lamb, is unnervingly realistic. And his religious scenes are just as austere, conveying suffering without drama. The show makes a clear case: Zurbarán may not have the fame of his peers, but he deserves it.

Photograph: AP

Formula 1’s Miami reset

Formula 1 faced a tight turnaround this year. New technical regulations and an off-season of just three months meant lots of manufacturers struggled to build fast, reliable cars in time for the first race of this season in March. Red Bull, which dominated between 2022 and 2024, is lagging. Mercedes’s drivers, George Russell and Kimi Antonelli, a baby-faced 19-year-old, won the first three races between them.

The Mercedes drivers face stiffer competition when the action resumes in Miami on Sunday. The cancellation of the Bahraini and Saudi Arabian races, caused by disruption from the war in Iran, gave teams an unexpected five weeks to make improvements. The McLaren team principal, Andrea Stella, has promised an “entirely new” car. This is hyperbole, but the scale of the changes to regulations means teams will tinker and experiment more than usual. That makes the drivers’s championship unpredictable.

Photograph: AP

Weekend profile: Zack Polanski, Britain's hypnotic eco-populist

On a typical day Zack Polanski likes his first post on Bluesky, a social-media site, at around 8.30am. His favourite times to scroll are between noon and 1pm, and from 6pm to 7pm. His last like usually happens around 11.15pm. After that, presumably, it's bedtime. The 43-year-old leader of the Green Party of England and Wales has liked almost 35,000 posts on Bluesky since April 2025. His hit rate has not slowed since he became leader in September. On May 1st Mr Polanski apologised for "sharing a tweet in haste", after he reposted a comment on X that questioned how police officers treated a man suspected of stabbing two Jewish men in north London. But he has been causing a stir offline too.

Mr Polanski, a forceful communicator, has shaken off the Greens' middle-class reputation. In February the party caused an upset when its candidate, a 34-year-old female plumber, won a parliamentary by-election in Greater Manchester. In local elections on May 7th it thinks it can win 1,000 council seats, one-in-five of those up for grabs; it is doing especially well in London.

Mr Polanski is a latecomer to electoral politics. He grew up in Manchester in a Jewish family, came out as gay as a teenager and spent two decades as an actor, boosting his income with odd jobs including hypnotherapist. In 2013 he told a reporter that he could

enlarge her breasts using “the unconscious” (he has since apologised). Two years later he joined the centrist Liberal Democrats but failed to mesmerise voters, standing unsuccessfully to be a councillor in London. He switched to the Greens in 2017. Eventually he was elected to the London Assembly, where he still sits.

The Economist’s poll tracker puts the Greens just three points behind Labour and the Conservatives, Britain’s two traditional parties of government. (Reform UK, a populist-right party led by Nigel Farage, is ahead of them all.) That is partly down to Labour, which in government has turned left-wing voters off. Much of it is thanks to Mr Polanski’s flashy policies, which include a wealth tax on billionaires, rent controls and maximum-pay ratios. The party has embraced “eco-populism”—emphasising social justice as much as climate change. Its lavish spending plans would be toxic for Britain’s economy.

Mr Polanski has reached voters with some unusual campaigning, including nightclub appearances (though he says he has never drunk alcohol or taken recreational drugs). He’s a fan of cheesy jokes and can be quick to make fun of himself. Yet he also seems thin-skinned, at least online. Dozens of posts he has liked include personal insults about journalists who have written about him. The party says “He is sorry for any mistakes made when working fast.” For now, Mr Polanski and the Greens show no sign of slowing down.

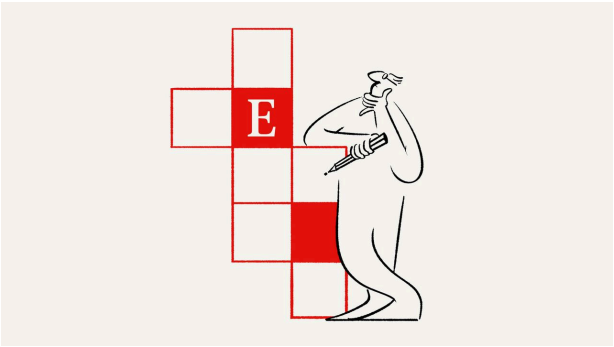


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Lineage without a stroke delivers vital fluid (5)

2 across - Russian vector's opposite drops hesitation, then recoils (4)

3 across - Pre-raphaelite ultimately was first class (5)

1 down - It's May Day! Running wild is tenable (7)

Straight clues

1 across - Thicker than the water of the womb (5)

2 across - The last one was Nicholas II (4)

3 across - Internet slang "l33t" derives from this word (5)

1 down - Gaelic festival held on first of May (7)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week’s quiz

The winners of this week’s quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week’s quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Isabelle de Hennin, Brussels, Belgium

Ahmed Alsuwaidi, Dubai, United Arab Emirates

Sulaiman Penseney, Victoria, Canada

They gave the correct answers of Doctor Doom, shire horse, the middle, the Petronas Towers and Billie Jean King. The theme is The Lord of the Rings books and films which feature Mount Doom and the Shire, are set in Middle-earth and have titles The Two Towers and The Return of the King

The questions were

Monday: Which character is the main archenemy of the Fantastic Four, in both the comic book and film series?

Tuesday: Which breed of horse, originating in England, was notable for its strength, being used to pull canal boats and brewers’ carts, as well as farm equipment?

Wednesday: The median appears at which point of a statistical distribution?

Thursday: Which buildings in Malaysia were the world's tallest from 1998 to 2004?

Friday: Which female tennis player took part in the Battle of the Sexes match against Bobby Riggs in 1973?

The noblest pleasure is the joy of understanding.

Leonardo Da Vinci